

Dignity, Stewardship, And Accountability In Eziwho Emenike Azunwo's "Rinya-Chiokike": A Liberal Feminist And Christian Reading

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Abstract.

African drama has consistently served as a critical medium for interrogating gender, power relations, morality, and social justice. In "Rinya-Chiokike", Eziwho Emenike Azunwo presents a sustained critique of the condition of womanhood within a patriarchal order, while also examining family responsibility, inheritance, Christian stewardship, empathy, and conjugal relations. Drawing on Liberal Feminist Theory, this paper examines how female characters negotiate and transgress structural constraints that limit their agency and social recognition. The study argues that the play transcends its immediate gender concerns by redefining stewardship and inheritance around responsibility, faithfulness, service, and godliness. Through the characterization of Rita, Rachel, Fumi, and Nkechi, Azunwo constructs archetypes of female strength, integrity, and intentionality. This is juxtaposed with the failures of male leadership, paternal irresponsibility, and performative religiosity embodied in Charles, Pastor Mike, and Dr. Ike. Ultimately, the play celebrates womanhood and affirms that genuine authority and inheritance are grounded in faith, ethical leadership, and good governance.

KEYWORDS: African Drama, Feminine Dignity, Stewardship, Liberal Feminism, Christian Ethics, "Rinya-Chiokike"

INTRODUCTION

African drama has historically functioned as a critical site for the interrogation of beliefs, values, customs, institutions, and social relations within diverse African contexts. From ritual performances to contemporary stage and screen drama, the theatre has served as both a mirror and a moulder of society. It provides a public forum where communal anxieties, aspirations, and contradictions are dramatized, debated, and, at times, resolved. Within this tradition, playwrights have consistently engaged questions of power, morality, identity, and justice, making drama a vital instrument for social commentary and transformation.

A recurring preoccupation within this corpus is the position of the woman in societies structured by gender stratification. Patriarchal systems across many African societies have historically mediated access to authority, leadership, economic resources, and public recognition along gendered lines. Consequently, the African woman has often been represented as marginalized, silenced, or confined to domestic and reproductive roles. Early postcolonial literature documented this condition, but in doing so, it sometimes reinforced the very stereotypes it sought to critique. The burden of this representation has prompted a new generation of writers to revisit the "woman question" with greater complexity.

While earlier African writers largely documented the plight of women within patriarchal

systems, contemporary playwrights have moved beyond documentation to critique these structures and to examine emerging configurations of gender, family, and religious values. This shift reflects broader socio-political changes, including women's increased participation in public life, education, and the church, as well as the influence of global feminist discourses. Modern African drama now interrogates not only external oppression but also internalized norms, complicity, and the possibilities of agency. In this context, the stage becomes a space for imagining alternative models of womanhood and leadership.

Eziwho Emenike Azunwo's "Rinya-Chiokike" belongs to this new wave of dramatic engagements. The play dramatizes the struggles, resilience, and faith of women navigating the constraints of a patriarchal order. Set within the Nigerian socio-cultural and religious milieu, the text foregrounds the everyday realities of women who negotiate family, community, and faith. This thematic concern aligns with Azunwo's broader scholarly engagement with gender-based violence and women's empowerment in Nigerian cultural texts, where he argues that domestic spaces often become sites for negotiating power, oppression, and resistance (Azunwo, 2022).

Through sharp dialogue and domestic settings, Azunwo captures the psychological and material toll of systemic gender inequality while refusing to portray women as mere victims.

Beyond gender, however, "Rinya-Chiokike" interrogates broader social and moral questions like, family responsibility, neglect, inheritance, Christian stewardship, and the dynamics of spousal and kinship relations. The play extends its critique to the institution of the church and to notions of leadership that are divorced from service. Through the experiences of Rita and Rachel, Azunwo foregrounds the burdens women bear within the family, the community, and the Nigerian nation-state. Their stories reveal how the denial of recognition and resources to women destabilizes not only individual households but the moral fabric of society.

The characterization in the play functions as a deliberate moral argument. The character of Charles embodies a critique of masculinity defined by self-interest, emotional detachment, and performative religiosity, with devastating consequences for his household. His interactions with religious figures such as Pastor Mike and Dr. Ike further expose the problem of inauthentic faith and leadership. In contrast, Nkechi, the play's narrator, functions as a moral compass who affirms the value of womanhood and celebrates women whose leadership, integrity, and commitment to family merit public acknowledgment. Female figures such as Rita, Rachel, Fumi, and Nkechi are thus constructed as archetypes of strength, honesty, and deliberateness.

This study therefore contends that "Rinya-Chiokike" is not merely a critique of patriarchy. It is, more fundamentally, a Christian and liberal feminist challenge to leadership, faithfulness, service, and responsible governance. Drawing on Liberal Feminist Theory, the paper argues that Azunwo redefines inheritance and stewardship not in terms of gender or lineage, but in terms of moral character, responsibility, and godliness. In doing so, the play proposes that the stability of the family and the society depends on the recognition and empowerment of women as co-stewards. The analysis that follows examines how the play achieves this redefinition through plot, characterization, and ideological framing.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Feminist literary criticism has gained considerable momentum over the last few decades as a

critical approach to reading literature. Early feminist thinkers such as Mary Wollstonecraft (1792/2004), John Stuart Mill (1869/2006), and Betty Friedan (1963/2013) challenged the systemic exclusion of women from education, political participation, and economic opportunity. From these foundational critiques emerged Liberal Feminism, which advocates for equality within existing social, legal, and institutional structures. Liberal feminists argue that gender inequity is not natural but constructed, and can therefore be redressed through reform, access, and recognition within the same frameworks that govern men's lives.

Feminist critics proceed from the premise that literary texts are inscribed with the patriarchal power structures of their societies. Elaine Showalter defines the project of feminist criticism as an attempt to "rescue women from oblivion and to make a re-evaluation of the woman as author and the woman as character." For Showalter, this involves recovering marginalized female voices and rereading canonical texts. Lois Tyson extends this by arguing that feminist criticism must "expose patriarchal constructions of the feminine" and identify moments within literature that open possibilities for female empowerment. Both perspectives insist that reading is a political act capable of revealing and resisting gendered ideology.[1979][2015]

In the African context, feminist criticism has developed distinct trajectories to respond to specific socio-cultural, political, and economic realities. African women scholars did not simply adopt Western feminist models but generated new frameworks that account for culture, community, kinship, and negotiation. Chikwenye Okonjo Ogunyemi coined "Womanism" to describe the intertwined struggles of African men and women within colonial and postcolonial contexts, emphasizing survival and wholeness over separatism. Molaria Ogundipe-Leslie further called for a multidimensional analysis of African women's situation, one that considers the "six mountains" of oppression including tradition, religion, and global structures.(1985)(1994)

Perhaps most relevant to this study is Obioma Nnaemeka's concept of "Nego-Feminism." Nnaemeka proposes a feminism of negotiation, compromise, and conciliation rather than confrontation. This approach recognizes the centrality of family, community, and cultural continuity in African societies, while still demanding women's inclusion and agency. Nego-Feminism is particularly useful for reading texts where female characters assert themselves not by rejecting tradition outright, but by renegotiating their place within it. This is evident in the strategies of female characters in "Rinya-Chiokike" who seek participation and recognition without abandoning the values of family, faith, and community.(2004). Recent Nigerian scholarship equally demonstrates that literary and cinematic narratives continue to expose the intersection between domestic violence, gender inequality, and women's empowerment. Azunwo (2022) argues that contemporary Nigerian creative works increasingly portray women as active negotiators of oppressive structures rather than passive victims.

Complementing these literary frameworks is African feminist theology. Mercy Amba Oduyoye, a leading African feminist theologian, argues that Christianity should affirm the dignity and equal value of women rather than be used to legitimize oppressive cultural practices. For Oduyoye, faith can be a source of empowerment, healing, and social transformation for women. This theological perspective resonates with "Rinya-Chiokike", where Christian stewardship is redefined not as a tool of male authority but as a call to service, responsibility, and justice. The play thus engages religion as a site of both critique and possibility for women.(2001)

In light of these critical traditions, Eziwho Emenike Azunwo's "Rinya-Chiokike" is situated at the intersection of Liberal Feminism, African feminist thought, and Christian theology. The play does not merely lament women's marginalization; it dramatizes women's struggle for recognition and inclusion while upholding values of companionship, responsibility, good stewardship, and community integration. By foregrounding characters such as Rita, Rachel, Fumi, and Nkechi, the play aligns with liberal feminist demands for equal access, with Nego-Feminist strategies of negotiation, and with Christian ethical imperatives for leadership and care. "Rinya-Chiokike" therefore contributes to an evolving discourse on gender, faith, and governance in contemporary African drama.

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

This study adopts Liberal Feminism as its primary theoretical framework, complemented by insights from African feminist thought and Christian feminist theology. Liberal Feminism provides the central analytical lens for examining questions of equality, agency, and institutional access in Eziwho Emenike Azunwo's "Rinya-Chiokike". African feminist thought and Christian feminist theology are deployed as supporting frameworks to account for the cultural, communal, and religious specificities that shape the lived experiences of women in the play. This tripartite approach allows for a reading that is both globally informed and locally grounded.

Liberal Feminism emerged from the works of Mary Wollstonecraft, John Stuart Mill, and Betty Friedan. It is predicated on the belief that men and women are rational beings of equal moral worth and should therefore have equal access to education, political rights, economic opportunities, and participation in social institutions. Unlike radical feminist approaches that call for the overthrow of existing structures, Liberal Feminism advocates for reform from within. It interrogates customs, traditions, and institutional practices that impede women's full realization, while seeking to integrate women into existing frameworks of governance, work, religion, and family. As John Stuart Mill argues, no society can achieve genuine progress until women are equally involved in both public and private life [1869/2006].

The relevance of Liberal Feminism to "Rinya-Chiokike" is evident in the struggles of Rita and Rachel. Rita's resistance to restrictive traditional expectations and her demand for equality within marriage exemplify the liberal feminist emphasis on individual rights and partnership. Similarly, Rachel's claim to inheritance challenges patriarchal conventions that privilege male heirs. Crucially, these female characters do not seek to dismantle the institutions of family and marriage. Rather, they demand fairness, inclusion, and mutual responsibility within them. This reformist posture aligns directly with the core tenets of Liberal Feminism.

To account for the cultural context of the play, this study integrates Obioma Nnaemeka's concept of Nego-Feminism. Nego-Feminism foregrounds negotiation, compromise, and dialogue as strategies for women's empowerment in African societies where family and community remain central. It departs from confrontationist models and instead emphasizes agency exercised within, and not necessarily against, existing structures. In "Rinya-Chiokike", Rita embodies this approach. While she firmly contests Charles' patriarchal authority, she does so through negotiation rather than rupture, seeking to preserve her marriage while asserting her dignity. This reflects an African feminist commitment to balance, relationship, and communal

continuity.(2004)

Finally, the framework is buttressed by African Christian feminist theology, particularly as articulated by Mercy Amba Oduyoye. Oduyoye argues that Christian teachings must affirm the equal dignity of women, given that both male and female are created in the image of God, an image that is gender-neutral. This theological perspective is dramatized in “Rinya-Chiokike” when Rita challenges religious hypocrisy by asserting: “Have you forgotten that we are equal in God's eyes? Aren't we both created in God's image?” By invoking scripture and doctrine, the play repositions Christian faith as a source of empowerment rather than subjugation.(2001)

In sum, this study uses Liberal Feminism as the primary analytical tool to explain female agency in “Rinya-Chiokike”, while drawing on Nego-Feminism and Christian feminist theology to interpret how that agency is exercised through negotiation, faith, stewardship, and responsibility within African familial and religious contexts.

DISCUSSION AND ANALYSIS

Patriarchy and the Marginalization of Women in “Rinya-Chiokike”

Eziwho Emenike Azunwo's “Rinya-Chiokike” presents a social order deeply structured by patriarchy, wherein male authority is normalized and women's roles are circumscribed by custom and expectation. Within this system, women are defined primarily in relation to men as wives, daughters, and mothers, and are consequently denied autonomous access to decision-making, resources, and public recognition. The play illustrates how patriarchy functions not only through overt domination but also through the internalization of limiting norms that constrain women's potential.

Rita's experience embodies this marginalization. Her aspirations and capacities are repeatedly measured against patriarchal expectations of subservience and domesticity. Similarly, Rachel's confrontation with issues of inheritance exposes how lineage and property are mediated through male privilege, effectively disinheriting women regardless of merit or need. Azunwo thus dramatizes the structural harm that patriarchy inflicts: it denies women freedom of choice and agency over their own lives, while presenting such denial as natural or divinely ordained.

However, the play does not end with lamentation. Through Rita and Rachel, Azunwo mounts a critique of these norms and foregrounds the importance of self-determination. This aligns with the core tenet of Liberal Feminism: that all individuals, regardless of gender, must be afforded equal opportunity to make choices about their lives and to participate fully in social institutions. By centring women who think, act, and lead, Azunwo reframes female characters not as victims, but as agents capable of challenging and reshaping their conditions.

Female Dignity and the Reclamation of Space

Beyond critique, “Rinya-Chiokike” engages in the project of reclaiming dignity and space for women. Dignity in the play is not granted by patriarchal structures; it is asserted by women through moral action, faith, and competence. Rita, Rachel, Fumi, and Nkechi are portrayed as women of high self-awareness, integrity, and resourcefulness. They demonstrate leadership not through domination but through service, wisdom, and ethical commitment.

Nkechi, as the narrator, functions as the moral voice that validates this reclamation. She consistently affirms that womanhood should be celebrated and that the contributions of women to family and community merit public acknowledgment. In doing so, Azunwo repositions women from the margins to the centre of social and moral discourse. This reclamation of space is both literal, women speaking, deciding, and inheriting, and symbolic, with women defining the terms of value, leadership, and virtue in society.

Nego-Feminism: Negotiation over Confrontation

The agency exercised by the female characters reflects the principles of Nego-Feminism. Rather than adopt a posture of outright rebellion, Rita negotiates with Charles and with the structures of marriage and family. She asserts her equality and rights while seeking to preserve the institution of marriage and the cohesion of the family. Her famous question, “Have you forgotten that we are equal in God's eyes? Aren't we both created in God's image?” This statement, is not a rejection of faith or family, but a demand that these institutions live up to their ethical ideals.

This strategy of negotiation, rather than confrontation, is significant. It reflects an African feminist understanding that change is most sustainable when it occurs within existing social fabrics. Azunwo thus shows that women can be transformative agents without being cast as destroyers of culture or tradition.

Christian Stewardship, Leadership, and Inheritance Redefined

Finally, the play redefines key concepts of Christian stewardship, leadership, and inheritance. Through the contrast between female and male characters, Azunwo argues that leadership and inheritance should be determined not by gender, but by character. Charles, Pastor Mike, and Dr. Ike represent failed models of leadership such as, ambition without empathy, authority without fatherliness, and religion without compassion. Their performative faith and neglect have destructive consequences for the family. Charles' emotional abandonment of Rita reflects what Azunwo (2022) identifies as the subtle manifestations of domestic violence, where neglect, emotional absence, and psychological domination become as destructive as physical abuse.

In contrast, the women embody stewardship as responsibility, faithfulness, service, and godliness. The play therefore advances a Christian feminist argument: that both men and women are created in God's image and are equally called to stewardship. Inheritance, in this moral economy, becomes less about material lineage and more about the transmission of values, integrity, and good governance. Azunwo's vision is thus one in which the health of the family and society depends on recognizing women as co-stewards and rightful heirs to leadership.

Rita's Will and the Politics of Inheritance

One of the most significant interventions in “Rinya-Chiokike” is the question of inheritance, dramatized through Rita's Will. In the Will, Rita bequeaths her property to her daughter, Rachel. This act directly challenges the customary practice whereby inheritance automatically devolves to the male child, irrespective of character or capacity, while the daughter receives only what is allocated by male relatives.

Rita's decision is not motivated by animosity toward men. Rather, it is grounded in her

assessment of sacrifice, trustworthiness, and responsibility. She recognizes in Rachel the competence and moral grounding necessary to steward the family's resources. By privileging merit over gender, the play critiques a system that equates inheritance with lineage and instead proposes a model based on stewardship and accountability.

Through Rachel, Azunwo further demonstrates that women are capable of fulfilling divinely ordained responsibilities of care and governance within the family. The transfer of property to Rachel thus becomes symbolic because it represents the recognition of women's God-given responsibility and their right to participate in the economic and moral continuity of the family.

Women as Breadwinners and Co-Stewards in Contemporary Society

The play's representation of women as central actors within the family and society resonates with contemporary realities in many Nigerian homes. Increasingly, women are no longer confined to traditional domestic roles. They contribute significantly to the financial, emotional, and social well-being of their families, often serving as co-breadwinners and primary caregivers. Despite this, their contributions frequently remain unrecognized, while male figures are accorded prominence regardless of their actual input.

Rita represents this contemporary woman. She is industrious, responsible, and invested in the welfare of her family and community, yet her labour and sacrifice are often taken for granted. Rachel, in turn, embodies the next generation of women who are prepared for leadership and responsibility. By rewarding Rachel with the Will, Rita affirms that leadership and stewardship are capacities bestowed by God and demonstrated through action, and that these should be recognized and entrusted accordingly.

In this way, the play "Rinya-Chiokike" aligns with Liberal Feminist demands for equal opportunity and with African and Christian feminist affirmations of women's role as co-stewards. The play argues that the stability and progress of the family, and by extension the nation, depend on acknowledging and empowering women whose contributions have long sustained social life.

Education, Voice, and Empowerment

"Rinya-Chiokike" underscores voice, consciousness, and self-expression as central to female empowerment. The female characters in the play are distinguished by wisdom, emotional intelligence, and moral clarity. Their capacity to articulate grievances and to condemn injustice functions as a political act. By speaking, Rita, Rachel, Fumi, and Nkechi refuse the silence that patriarchy demands and instead insert themselves into social discourse.

Azunwo suggests that a productive and just society is one in which women are heard, acknowledged, and integrated into structures of decision-making and leadership. This aligns with Liberal Feminism's emphasis on equal participation in public institutions. Voice here is not merely speech, but agency, which is the ability to name problems, propose alternatives, and influence outcomes. The play therefore frames empowerment as both an individual and a collective process: when women speak, the community gains access to perspectives and solutions that would otherwise be excluded.

Faith, Stewardship, and Divine Justice

Beyond its feminist concerns, “Rinya-Chiokike” operates as a Christian drama that engages questions of spirituality, purpose, and divine justice. The play foregrounds the theological principle that human beings are created in the image of God, and therefore possess equal worth before the Creator irrespective of gender. On this basis, it interrogates social institutions that assign value and privilege based on gendered position within the family or society.

Rachel's inheritance of Rita's estate dramatizes the Christian concept of stewardship. Like the faithful servants in Christ's parable of the talents, Rachel is entrusted with responsibility not as a privilege but as a reward for demonstrated character like, responsibility, sacrifice, and dependability. Inheritance is thus redefined from a matter of lineage to a matter of moral stewardship.

The play further argues that tradition must be subjected to the test of truth and justice. Customs that produce inequality or harm are not sacrosanct simply because they are old. By dramatizing the consequences of unjust traditions, Azunwo calls for a critical engagement with culture in light of Christian ethics.

Marriage, Equality, and the Contestation of Biblical Authority

One of the most crucial scenes in the play is the dialogue between Charles and Rita on authority, marriage, and equality. Charles asserts a patriarchal interpretation of headship as seen in this dialogue, “Have you forgotten that I'm placed as the head over you?” For him, headship signifies dominion and unilateral control.

Rita offers a counter-exegesis grounded in equality: “Don't quote the bible to try and make me a slave. Have you forgotten that we are equal in God's eyes? Aren't we both created in God's image?” This statement articulates the play's liberal feminist and Christian feminist position. Rita does not reject Christianity or marriage. Rather, she rejects an interpretation of scripture that reduces women to objects of subservience.

Her vision of marriage is one of companionship and mutual consultation: “By virtue of marriage and bound by love and God's blessings, we are one, Charles. It is good that you make decisions but there are certain decisions, if not all, that need my input.” She affirms her husband's role while insisting that leadership requires collaboration: “Without my input to assist you, the foundation of our home will fall flat.”

Charles, however, extends patriarchal logic beyond the domestic sphere into the church and even the afterlife: “You can't be my equal in any form, be it here in the house, in the church, or in the world to come.” He attempts to sanctify cultural patriarchy as divine ordinance. Rita's final rebuttal reclaims theology for equality: “Up in the kingdom of God. Before Him we are equal, in love and in His mercies.” Her concluding assertion, “My God doesn't think like men do”, separates divine justice from male cultural bias.

This exchange stages a contest between two models of Christian belief. One model authorizes male dominance under the guise of biblical authority. The other, advanced by Rita, advocates for partnership, mutuality, and equality before God. Through this, Azunwo positions Christian

marriage not as hierarchy, but as a covenant of love, responsibility, and shared stewardship.

RELATION TO PRESENT-DAY NIGERIAN SOCIETY

The issues dramatized in Eziwho Emenike Azunwo's "Rinya-Chiokike" includes inheritance practices, female leadership, family responsibility, absentee fatherhood, emotional abandonment, spiritual fraud, Christian ethics of marriage, and gender equity which remain salient in contemporary Nigerian society.

The play depicts a society in transition, where traditional stereotypes and patriarchal norms are being pressured by changing socio-economic and religious realities. Women are increasingly visible as breadwinners, decision-makers, and moral leaders, yet institutional and cultural structures continue to lag behind this reality. In this context, "Rinya-Chiokike" functions as both critique and intervention. It calls for a reorientation of values around responsibility, fairness, inclusiveness, partnership, and mutuality as the necessary foundations for family and national progress. By grounding this call in both liberal feminist principles and Christian ethics, the play argues that social transformation is possible without the destruction of family, faith, or community.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Based on the findings of this study, the following recommendations are made:

On Inheritance and Family Customs: Families should uphold customs of inheritance that prioritize contribution, responsibility, and character over gender-based favouritism. Merit, rather than sex, should determine who is entrusted with family resources and leadership.

On Women's Leadership and Participation: Women must be encouraged and supported to assume leadership positions and to exercise full participatory rights in decision-making at the levels of family, church, and community.

On Child Socialization: Parents and educators should instil in both male and female children the ethics of responsibility, integrity, stewardship, and service as core values for personal and social life.

On Religious Institutions: Religious organizations must champion authentic stewardship and discourage spiritual fraud and performative religiosity. Biblical teachings on marriage and leadership should be interpreted to emphasize partnership and mutuality rather than domination.

On Education and Cultural Production: Schools, universities, and community organizations should utilize literary texts such as "Rinya-Chiokike" to facilitate discourse on gender equity, Christian principles, and social responsibility.

On Scholarship: Scholars should continue to engage contemporary African drama to examine evolving representations of religion, marriage, gender, and the family.

On Community Recognition: Communities must consciously acknowledge and celebrate women's contributions to economic, social, and moral life, and integrate these contributions into

public narratives of progress.

By implementing these recommendations, Nigerian society can move closer to the vision of justice, equity, and responsible governance articulated in “Rinya-Chiokike”.

CONCLUSION

Read through the lens of Liberal Feminist theory, Eziwho Emenike Azunwo's “Rinya-Chiokike” emerges as both a vehement critique of patriarchal attitudes and a celebration of women's moral, spiritual, and leadership capacities. Through the differentiated portrayals of Rita, Rachel, and Nkechi, the play dramatizes women's ability to exercise agency, demonstrate resilience, exhibit faith, and effect social change. These characters refute the notion of women as passive dependents and instead present them as pathfinders, stewards, and moral authorities within the family and society.

However, “Rinya-Chiokike” transcends the boundaries of feminist discourse. It engages broader ethical and theological questions concerning responsibility, inheritance, familial devotion, Christian stewardship, and the ethics of marriage. Through the tragic figure of Charles, Azunwo condemns absentee fatherhood, self-centred leadership, emotional neglect, and the manipulation of religious authority for selfish ends. Charles functions as an anti-type whose failures underscore the play's central moral argument: that authority without empathy and service is illegitimate.

Ultimately, “Rinya-Chiokike” advances the proposition that leadership is not determined by gender, position, or title, but by character, integrity, accountability, faith, love, and service. As both a feminist narrative that exposes the injustice of exclusion and a Christian treatise that advocates for fairness, spiritual responsibility, and the celebration of women's inherent excellence, the play issues a clarion call. It urges Nigerian society to build relationships, homes, churches, and communities founded on mutual respect, cooperation, partnership, and godly love.

Beyond the stage, the play holds immediate relevance for present-day Nigerian families and institutions. At a time when women increasingly function as co-breadwinners and primary caregivers, yet remain excluded from inheritance and leadership structures, “Rinya-Chiokike” provides a moral template for reform. Its advocacy for merit-based inheritance, consultative marriage, and accountable leadership speaks directly to ongoing debates about gender equity, religious practice, and family stability in Nigeria. By dramatizing the social cost of emotional abandonment and spiritual fraud, the play warns that the erosion of ethical responsibility within the home inevitably weakens the larger community.

In addition, “Rinya-Chiokike” contributes significantly to contemporary African dramatic literature and feminist theology. It offers a model of “negotiated agency” that is culturally resonant: one that does not seek to abolish family or faith, but to redeem them through justice and partnership. This positions the play as an important pedagogical and scholarly resource for discussions on religion, gender, and governance in Africa. Future studies can profitably explore how Azunwo's integration of liberal, African, and Christian feminist thought provides a framework for reimagining African modernity as one that affirms both tradition and transformation. Thus, “Rinya-Chiokike” stands not only as literature, but as ethical advocacy

for a society where dignity and stewardship are measured by service rather than by sex.

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